

ANNA NAGAR

Purasawalkam » Villivakkam » Kolathur » Nazarathpettai » Pattabiram » Maduravoyal » Koyambedu » Tiruverkadu » Puzhal » Kilpauk » Perambur » Mogappair

Avadi » Ayyappakkam » Tiruninravur » Nerkundram » Moolakadai » Ayanavaram » Retteri » Padi » Ambattur » Tirumullaivoyal » Aminjikarai » Vysarpadi » Red Hills

## ‘Newly laid road **dug up** for SWD work’

Recently installed bollards and handrails have been removed



The SWD work on Perambur High Road - North.

RAGHUKUMAR CHOODAMANI

**G**reater Chennai Corporation (GCC) recently relaid a stretch of Perambur High Road - North, that is from Perambur railway station to B.B. Road intersection.

But this road work could have waited. It could have commenced after the stormwater drain restoration work got completed. The drain work began just a fortnight ago and a week before that the road was relaid. Now, the new road has been dug up due to SWD work.

Besides, bollards were installed on the footpath a few days before the drain work began. (The stormwater drain, along the compound wall of Perambur railway station doubles as a footpath here). And those bollards have been removed now. Likewise, stainless steel handrails installed along the footpath a few months ago have been removed now.

And sometime in October 2024, a fresh coat of paint was given to the manholes of the dilapidated stormwater drain. Most of the manholes were broken. Yet another pointless exercise.

Restoration of the decades-old stormwater drain on this road was planned two years ago under North Chennai Development Scheme. While there is a plan to demolish the existing SWD, why is GCC spending on other works that are sure to be done away with?

The order in which these infrastructure projects are being carried out on Perambur High Road - North is absurd and unreasonable. They are nothing but a waste of tax payers' money.

It may also be noted the public does not even use the footpath because it is broken and unhygienic as it is misused as an open urinal. Providing amenities on a footpath

that is out of bounds for pedestrians does not make sense.

From time to time, Perambur Neighbourhood Development Forum has been raising the issue of misplaced priorities in carrying out infrastructure works.

If GCC is earnest about ensuring safety on this road, it could have focused on the opposite side of the road which is plagued by illegal parking. Here, many commercial establishments including restaurants, bakeries, and a TASMAR-run liquor shop are located. The vehicles of the customers of these shops eat into sizeable road space. And near the railway station where metro rail construction is under way, a line of autorickshaws are parked along the road. All these compromise safety. Pedestrians are forced to walk in the middle of the road running the risk of being hit by vehicles.

Perambur Neighbourhood Development Forum has been requesting GCC and the traffic police to attend to these issues but nothing has been done to this end.

### Madhavaram High Road

Another example of criminal waste of the public exchequer. The footpath on Madhavaram High Road is being relaid with concrete paver blocks. But a section of the new footpath has been torn up within a few weeks to carry out a stormwater drain work. The work is about connecting the SWD to the one on Patel Road. What is the point in constructing and then breaking it.

All these speak of poor coordination between GCC departments engaged with SWD construction and roads.

Both Perambur High Road - North and Madhavaram High Road are in Ward 71 in Zone 6 - Thiru Vi Ka Nagar.

*Raghukumar Choodamani is the convenor of Perambur Neighbourhood Development Forum*

## ‘We need a road that gives no room for flooding’

Perambur Neighbourhood Development Forum, a citizens group from Perambur in Thiru Vi Ka Nagar Assembly Constituency, wants robust road infrastructure that is safe for pedestrians, motorists and gives no room for flooding.

“Key roads, the subways and the bus terminus in Perambur go under water during rains, because the decades-old stormwater drain network serves no purpose. Another reason is flouting of rules; that is, the roads have not been laid in conformity to IRC guidelines, especially with respect to gradient and milling. All these cause heavy waterlogging that lasts for a week. The roads and their footpaths are also plagued by encroachments and illegal parking. Further, an incomplete median work is



Perambur High Road - North in December 2025.

PHOTO: B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

causing accidents on Perambur High Road - North,” says Raghukumar Choodamani, convenor of the forum. The forum notes that this has been its major demand during previous Assembly elections and it remains unmet to this day.

In its list of demands, the citizens group insists on a

government that will enforce and conform to the prescribed rules and norms with an iron hand. And it wants regular conduct of Ward-level meetings with elected representatives and officials. Yet another demand is a performance audit of the services offered by the State Government.

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## ‘GCC-run cemetery in Kilpauk in a state of neglect’



The cemetery on Cemetery Road in Kilpauk.  
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

**ANN XAVIER**

The images taken on March 25, 2026 show a staggering lack of upkeep of the Greater Chennai Corporation-run cemetery on Cemetery Road in Kilpauk. The place is strewn with plastics, clothes and construction debris.

Furthermore, dense vegetation obscures the graves and the pathways making it difficult for families to pay their respects to their departed loved ones. All these betray lack of regular cleaning.

A cemetery should be a place of peace and solemnity, but this facility in Kilpauk has been reduced to

a dumping ground.

Residents from Chetpet, Perambur and nearby areas use this cemetery.

*Ann Xavier is a resident of Jamalía*

## ‘Unsafe speed breakers in school zone’



TI School Road in Ambattur. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

**S. SURESH**

Being in a school zone, TI School Road at Thiruvengada Nagar needs not just speed breakers, but those that are effective and safe. But plastic speed breakers have been laid, and these put motorcyclists at risk for accidents.

These speed breakers raise the

risk of skidding and besides, motorists regular on this road might develop spine-related ailments. We have been pursuing this issue with the officials of Greater Chennai Traffic Police and Greater Chennai Corporation but our complaints have gone in vain.

*S. Suresh is the president of United Welfare Associations of Ambattur*

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## ‘Tristar Park Road is unkempt’

**BADRINATH.K**

The image shows parking of vehicles along Tristar Park Road in Mogappair Eri Scheme. These vehicles, most of them confiscated by police, take up a sizeable road space. Further, the road is not swept regularly. Complaints to Greater Chennai Corporation were to no avail.

*Badrinath.K is a resident of Mogappair*



## ‘Illegal parking hinders traffic flow’

**K.V. RAMESH NAIR**

The image shows parking of heavy vehicles along the service lanes of Poonamalee High Road in Velappanchavadi. This junction witness heavy traffic flow. But parking of vehicles eats into the road space and creates traffic congestion, especially during peak hours. Complaints to traffic police have gone in vain.

*K.V. Ramesh Nair is a resident of Poonamalee High Road*



## ‘Relay GNG First Street’



GNG First Street and (right) GNG Street. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

**T. GUNASEELAN**

GNG Street in Ambattur was relaid recently. Further, a speed breaker has also been provided. This street connects CTH Road with Ambattur railway station and hence witnesses good traffic; and, so needs to be relaid without any delay.

I request GCC to relay GNG First Street too. This is another important road that provides connectivity to the railway station. Only a patchwork was done on this road a couple of years ago. GCC should do the needful.

*T. Gunaseelan is a resident of Ambattur*





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# The pink route to empowering women

On March 31, Rotary District 3234 will be distributing its second batch of pink autos to beneficiaries it has selected with a fine-tooth comb

LIFFY THOMAS

**T**hese bright pink autos have become a familiar sight on Chennai roads. Driven by women and catering primarily to women and children, pink autos are on the rise thanks to various social organisations and a scheme promoted by the Social Welfare and Women Empowerment Department of the Tamil Nadu Government to fund women (partially, in most cases) to own and drive these vehicles.

The pink fleet ticks several boxes: women empowerment, women's participation in the labour force, promoting a clean environment (CNG is used as fuel) and breaking gender stereotypes.

According to ballpark figure, Chennai must be having more than 500 pink women autorickshaw drivers and this number is only on the rise.

On March 31, Rotary District 3234 will be distributing its second batch of pink autos, close to 27 (its second major drive after it launched the project in August 2025 to distribute 100 pink autos in an event held at Chennai Trade Centre).

The District engages the service of ANEW (Association for Non-Traditional Employment for Women) to identify and train deserving women. Basics of martial arts and communication skills are also covered under the training.

"Our beneficiaries have to update us at least once a month about the status of their EMIs. So far, we have 85 who are prompt in doing that," says Siva Ilango van, chairman - Pink Auto Project, Rotary District 3234.

## Supporting drivers

Rotary District 3233 initiated the Pink Auto Project in 2019 and till date has given away 153 autos for women. Rotarian Shanthi Sel-



(Right) Shanthi Selvam, chairperson of the Pink Auto Project, Rotary District 3233, with a beneficiary. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Under the project, women auto drivers train aspiring candidates. "Jothi Lakshmi, for instance, one of our first beneficiaries has trained many women, many a time spending money from her own pocket and has bought her own house with her income. Likewise, Saritha from Ashok Nagar goes to other localities to offer classes," she says.

To ensure these women have a steady income, the Club associates with various Interact and Rotract Clubs.

"Rotary Club of Madras North West is under our umbrella. We connected Selvi, residing in the area, with the Club who was put in touch with Velankanni School in Ashok Nagar that has an Interact Club. Students who needed transport now use her service," says Shanthi.

Associating with a social organisation also means these women enjoy other benefits. "Rajan Eye Hospital has tied up with us to offer free eye care for all pink auto drivers and their families, including funding their cataract surgeries," says Shanthi.

## Tough rules

According to Tamil Nadu Motor Vehicle Rules, only women are authorised to operate pink autos. To be eligible to apply for an auto under the Pink Auto scheme of the State Government, a woman must be between 20 and 45 years of age. P.V. Raji Ashok, a senior auto driver from Perambur, feels having a cut-off restricts many deserving women from entering the field.

She also feels it is unfair to take action if pink autos are operated by men. "My neighbour met with an accident the day she brought the pink auto and could not drive for six months. How will she repay the loan?" she asks.

There should be some authority these women can approach to seek exception when they cannot drive for genuine reasons, says Raji, who has been an auto driver since 1998.

vam, who has been chairperson of the project since its inception, says one of the biggest success stories of the project is that none of its women beneficiaries have sold their autos despite various challenges on and off the road. That is because they follow a rigorous process in selecting the most deserving persons (single women and widows are accorded preference in the selection process) and support them till they manage a steady income. Driving these vehicles is a big step toward financial independence for these women.

Of the ₹3 lakh purchase cost of an auto run on CNG, 50 percent is

borne by the Rotary District and the rest by the beneficiary who takes a bank loan, which is to be repaid by her in instalments.

"For women whose CIBIL score does not qualify them for a loan, we arrange for the loan by tying up with a private financial institution," says Shanthi, adding that they give away pink autos as and when they find sponsors.

"Finding sponsors is a challenge, and we have not reached out for CSR funds," she says adding that these women can earn between ₹1,500 and ₹ 2,000 a day.



For women whose CIBIL score does not qualify them for a loan, we arrange for the loan by tying up with a private financial institution





# Mega career counselling fair on April 11 and 12

Conducted by  
*The Hindu*  
*EducationPlus*,  
the fair is in its  
23th edition

**T**he *Hindu Education-Plus* is conducting the 23rd edition of The Hindu EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair 2026 on April 11 and 12 from 10 a.m. to 6 p.m. at the Chennai Trade Centre, Convention Hall.

The exhaustive fair for parents and students from classes 9 to 12 will empower aspiring young minds to make informed career decisions from 40 plus institutions and help them choose the right courses and colleges. Top educational and financial institutions from across India will be present. Furthermore, career guidance sessions with domain experts will help people dis-

cuss their career plans.

This annual fair is a great chance for students and parents to explore different career paths, learn about college admissions, and gain insights into various fields of

study.

A plethora of options awaits students as they get ready to finish their schooling, much more than ever before. There is a wide range of courses to choose from,

careers to aspire to, and areas of interest to delve into. In every edition, the fair has aimed to give students insights into several areas, cater to their interests, and open a world of educational opportunities for them.

The latest edition of the career Counselling fair will have all of this and make this experience possible for students by giving them the platform to engage with experts across diverse fields and representatives from various educational and financial institutions. Keeping up with the needs of the students, *The Hindu Education-*

*Plus* has been organising career expos to aid students looking to pursue higher education both in India and overseas.

Spot admissions and scholarships await the students at the fair along with surprise gifts for the first 200 entries on both the days. To know more about the sessions and the fair, contact: +91 90940 41021, 9962226550 and 9841298938.

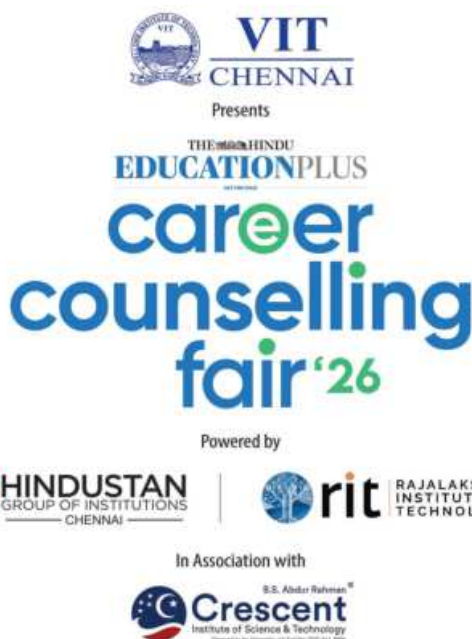
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REPRESENTATIONAL PICTURE



R. RAGU

**A**rtisans in Chintadripet specialising in lace garlands are going beyond the regular run-of-the-mill specifications. Even customisations through the year will fit certain patterns, monotonously recurring.

Customisations currently being pursued follow a whole new pattern. This is a pattern that repeats once every few years. These artisans are now putting faces to the lace gardens, powerful faces. Based on orders from political parties in Tamil Nadu, they personalise the lace garlands and kritams (crowns) with the faces of leaders of those institutions.

The colours of party flags are woven into the lace garlands.

The lace garlands are qualified as sandalwood lace garlands as scented sandalwood shavings are part of what goes into their making.

These wood shavings are also crafted into decorative items that jazz up the garlands. There are also lace garlands that use cardamom to define the character of their strings.

The kritams (crowns) are made taller by artfully stacking currency notes, which is essentially about the party going the extra mile, a costly mile at that, to honour its leaders and candidates.

The makers of lace garlands are artisans with an expertise that



## Power art

The lace garlands woven by the artisans in Chintadripet take on a new character ahead of elections

has been passed down the generations; and their shops are found on two streets in Chintadripet, namely Ayya Street and Arunachalam Street.

These families are also part of Chintadripet, youngsters taking the baton from their seniors and forbears, as is the case with Thulasi Sha with a shop on Ayya

Street.

There are two sets of artisans in these two streets of Chintadripet, one specialising in lace garlands, and other in those wide, elaborately embellished temple umbrellas. The peak season for the sale of temple umbrellas is October or the Tamil month of Puratasi.



In Chintadripet, a shop making lace garlands and crowns is customising them currently for political parties. PHOTOS: R. RAGU



# The *swap* code

This has nothing to do with computer programming, but with an initiative that encourages participants to consider doing a swap on household items that might have outgrown their home but still has a place in somebody else's. Welcome to three online groups started by sustainability enthusiast and volunteer Swathi Ramanathan from Kasturba Nagar in Adyar

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Perfectly usable furniture, electronic goods, utensils and books often end up discarded because households have outgrown them. While volunteering for waste collection drives Kasturba Nagar resident Swathi Ramanathan regularly came across this anomaly and felt prompted to start two online groups, both with a WhatsApp and Telegram presence, that encourage swapping over shopping, wherever that is possible, and give gently used household items and books a new address where they are cherished all over again. In addition, following a discussion in one of these swap groups, she also formed a group where participants can learn about free wellness programmes much before they are rolled out.

## Swap Don't Shop

At last count, around 1,500 residents of Chennai follow that imperative, always asking themselves whether they can swap and not shop. A WhatsApp-based initiative that spilled over to Telegram, the group enables swapping of household goods. Born on 15 July 2024 in WhatsApp, where it has hit the ceiling being packed with 1025 members, Swap Don't Shop has had to find an additional home in Telegram, where it commands the following of over 500 members. The author of the initiative, Kasturba Nagar resident Swathi Ramanathan, felt the need for this group while coordinating waste collection drives as a volunteer of Residents of Kasturba Nagar Association (ROKA). During these drives, she repeatedly noticed items still in good condition being discarded. "We saw many usable household items being thrown away. We believe a product has to be used till its lifetime comes to an end," says Swathi. Initially launched as a clothes exchange group by Swathi along with Vaishnavi Venkatesh, the platform was later expanded to include all household items after the early model failed to gain traction.

Transactions follow clear guidelines: only household items without expiry dates are allowed, and plants are welcomed. Members post photos with detailed descriptions, including brand, age, dimensions, condition, price, and pickup location. Delivery is coordinated directly between

buyer and seller, occasionally involving porters for larger items. The platform has enabled beneficiaries ranging from domestic help needing textbooks and study guides to expatriates seeking short-term household items like Golu dolls. While logistical challenges, pricing issues, and trust concerns occasionally arise, Swathi believes the initiative finds itself sustained by a sense of community and purpose felt by members.

## Chennai Book Bridge

Chennai Book Bridge is a Diwali gift to those who still swear by the physical book, while also consuming information digitally. Again, the idea of starting this group occurred to Swathi during waste collection drives. She came across many people who wanted to part with their books, but only with those who will cherish those books. She decided on starting a book-swapping WhatsApp group, which has now grown to nearly 300 members, most of whom are senior citizens and regular readers who prefer physical books. Beyond book exchange and donations, the group encourages discussions on authors, genres, literary events, and book-to-film adaptations, creating an interactive reading community. Swathi notes that these discussions have become a defining feature. "It is a lovely group... there are so many things I myself didn't know about authors and books," she says.

Although a Telegram version was introduced to organise discussions by genre, participation remains stronger on WhatsApp due to the older user base. Challenges, such as reselling low-value books or managing occasional rude behaviour, are moderated with clear guidelines emphasising good faith. Swathi elaborates, "We cannot control everything, but we ensure the platform remains respectful and focused on reading."

## Nalam Chennai Wellness Connect

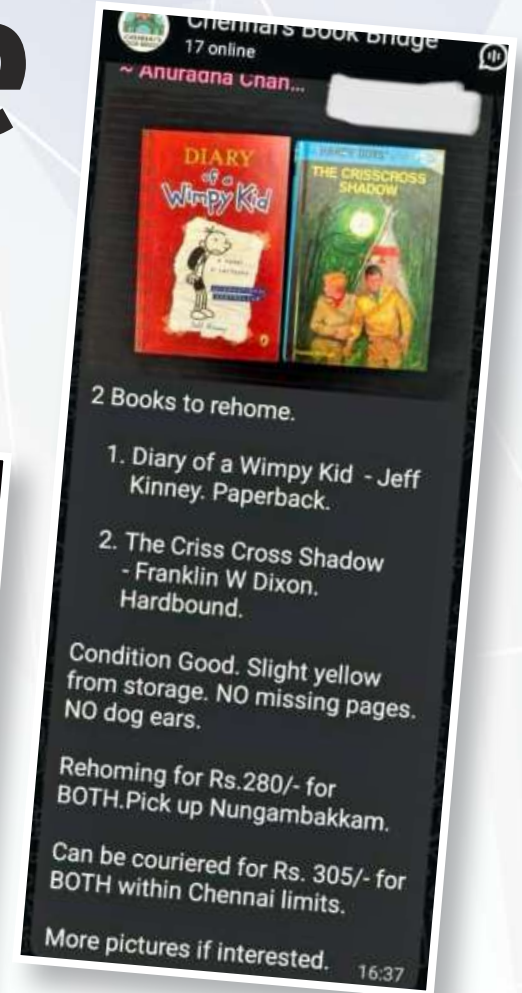
Free wellness camps have a way of eluding timely notice. Often times, they come to light as a post-event report in a website or a newspaper. Nalam Chennai Wellness Connect, present on WhatsApp and Telegram group, is an effort to bring visibility to free wellness programmes (yoga classes, health camps and so on) much before they start rolling so that people can attend and benefit from

them. Free yoga classes, free health camps

The idea began as an offshoot of the Swap Don't Shop initiative. "We wanted to brainstorm with participants about their interests. One of the interests was the wellness group. They said they wanted to know more about what was happening in the city in terms of wellness."

Members themselves can share details of free wellness services, provided the information is authentic. Swathi has shared updates on government initiatives, like free HPV vaccinations for adolescents. Currently, the group has 87 members on WhatsApp and 21 on Telegram, forming a small but growing network connecting Chennai residents to wellness opportunities that won't cost them a rupee.

For joining any of these groups, contact Swathi Ramanathan at 93812 02054





## Identifying the hidden talent in each child

Annual day fete at Gurukulam Special School in Anna Nagar was an eye-opener



**G**urukulam Special School in Anna Nagar celebrated its annual day, one marking the completion of seven years, with a wonderful performance.

Students showcased their abilities and potential through various performances such as fancy dress, fusion dance, ramp walk, skit, group dance, yoga, pyramid formation, recitation of slokas, poems, singing, speech and instrumental music.

It was not easy for these students as most of them are sensitive to sound, light, crowd and costumes of various textures. The event was made possible with the

hard working and creative team of staffers who exhibited utmost patience in training the students, says a press release.

The ambience of the space also contributed to the success of the programme. The press note thanks Adhithya Hotel, Vadapalani for being a well wisher and supporting the school. The caring and affectionate atmosphere helped the students to be at their best, it adds.

**Students showcased their abilities and potential through various performances.**

## Assistive devices distributed at camp

**S**ri Kanyaka Parameswari Arts and Science College for Women, in association with Bhagwan Mahaveer Viklang Sahayata Samiti (BMVSS) and Surana and Surana Public Charitable Trust, conducted a mega Jaipur foot camp recently. Sponsored by DP World, the three-day camp was aimed at providing free assistive devices and rehabilitation support to persons with disabilities across Tamil Nadu, said a release. L.Sundaresan, Additional Solicitor General of Tamil Nadu, graced the valedictory function.

A total of 634 registrations were received from beneficiaries representing various districts of Tamil Nadu. Following thorough medical assessment and evaluation, individuals



were identified as beneficiaries, receiving customised mobility and support aids based on their specific needs, said the release.

In total, 915 assistive devices such as artificial limbs, artificial hands, calipers, crutches, wheelchairs and tri-

## Isai Pudhidu turns three

The group celebrated its anniversary with a celebration at Anandham old age home in Ambattur



**I**sai Pudhidu, a voluntary group of singers who started as a WhatsApp group, celebrated its third anniversary at Anandham old age home in Ambattur on March 21.

The initiative, led by writer, poet, journalist and publisher Azhagiya, aims to transform casual 'bathroom singers' into professional performers in both Carnatic and film music, said a press

release.

K. Sankaranarayanan, a senior member of the group who retired from a bank and is a poet, composer and singer, was honoured on the occasion. His book 'Isai Amudhu' comprising 100 devotional songs was released at the event by Azhagiya and the first copy was received by Parvathy Balakrishnan, admin at the old age home. Narayanan,

a senior member of Anandham, explained the multiple activities at the home including school for special children and the goushala.

'Sangeetha Bala Padam', an initiative to teach basic music lessons by Kasturi Vasudevan was also presented.

The entire music programme was coordinated by Indra Ramathan, added the release.

## Selection for MUN Europe

Speak Your Mind is organising the 'MUN Europe Selection Programme' to identify students who can represent India at an international conference. The selection rounds will be held on May 15 and 16 at Career Launcher, Alwarpet.

The top 10 delegates will be selected to represent India at MUN Europe, scheduled to take place in Malta from October 7-9, 2026, said a release.

This initiative aims to provide students with global exposure and build skills in diplomacy, public speaking, and leadership.

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## Vocational awards presented

Rotary Club of Chennai Tower, a unit of Rotary International District 3233, organised its annual vocational service award event recently.

According to a press release, N Silambarasan, better known as "Silambam Silambu" from Ponneri was presented with Vocational Service Award - Young Achiever in Sports in recognition of his expertise in martial art, Silambam.

The Vocational Service Award - Social Service was presented to Selvakumar, a tailor from Virudhunagar. He has trained a large number of underprivileged women in tailoring with an aim to empower them for a fee of ₹1.

S Padma, a 48-year-old conservancy worker from Chennai was presented with Vocational Service Award - Epitome of Ethics Icon for the prompt return of 45 sovereigns of gold jewellery that

she discovered during her duty. The award aims to honour her exceptional honesty.

Nimal Raghavan, an engineer-turned-environmentalist, was honoured for his work on conservation of lakes. He was presented with Vocational Service Award - Environmental Preservation.

Vocational Service Award - Lifetime Achievement was presented to Bharatanatyam exponent Leela Samson, adds the release.



## A space for shared healing

Golden Butterflies Children's Palliative Care Foundation conducted its third grief and bereavement circle

On March 21, Golden Butterflies Children's Palliative Care Foundation conducted its third Grief and Bereavement Circle 'Finding Strength in Loss' at Madras School of Social Work College, bringing together 10 families in a safe and compassionate space to remember, reflect and connect.

The session created an environment where parents could express their emotions openly, while also finding strength in one another's presence. The event featured a special address by Dr. R. Vijalakshmi, Professor and Head, Department of Cancer Biology and Molecular Diagnostics, Cancer Institute. Having walked a similar journey herself, her reflections resonated deeply with the families, making her presence especially meaningful and comforting, said a release.

Participants engaged with a series of reflective stations designed around the theme of food, memory, and shared experiences. The Food Memory Installation invited families to reconnect with their loved ones through memories of meals, tastes, and everyday moments. An audio station offered a quiet space for personal reflection, while a reflection table with prompts encouraged participants to express thoughts, memories, and emotions in their own way.

The gathering concluded with a music healing session by Vennu Singh and Hema, Healer & Lightworker which was deeply soothing and offered a gentle sense of closure, added the release.

The session highlighted the importance of creating such spaces for collective healing and ongoing support.

## Honour for Perambur resident



Perambur resident Dr. S. Jimson, who is an oral and maxillofacial surgeon, has been invited to join the Membership Committee of the International Association of Oral and Maxillofacial Surgeons (IAOMS) in the capacity of Asian representative.

The announcement, shared by the Association of Oral and Maxillofacial Surgeons of India (AOMSI) Tamil Nadu & Puducherry Branch, highlights this as a significant milestone for regional representation on the global stage, said a press-release.

Currently serving as Treasurer of AOMSI nationally, Executive Committee Member of the Asian Association of Oral and Maxillofacial Surgeons (Asian AOMS), and Immediate Past President of the AOMSI TN & Puducherry Branch, Dr. Jimson is based in Chennai and practices at Jims Dental Care.

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